Lashkar based on confessions obtained from several co-conspirators, but the Indian Supreme Court later ruled these confessions were inadmissible because they were obtained improperly.[47] All of those later convicted in India belonged to JeM, and in 2004 General Javed Ashraf Qazi (Retd), a former director-general of the ISI, publicly blamed it for the attack.[48] It is possible Lashkar or elements associated with the group provided assistance, but all of those known to be involved belonged to JeM and the attack is generally considered to be a Jaish-operation.

It does not appear that the leadership in the Pakistani government or military sanctioned the operation. Senior US officials who were interviewed several years later for a report on the crisis that developed following the Parliament attack doubted Musharraf would have risked war with India or complicating his burgeoning post-9/11 relationship with Washington.[49] Based on telephone calls made by the attackers prior to the assault, a senior level ISI official is believed to have authorized the operation.[50] One Pakistani reporter who investigated the attack asserted that the Brigadier General who handled militant groups in India-controlled Kashmir for the ISI gave the go-ahead.[51] Musharraf was reportedly furious about the attack because he knew it could mean a showdown either with India or the jihadi proxies he was working so hard to protect.[52] Because of a policy in which proxies and their ISI handlers operated without critical oversight in order to maintain plausible deniability, red lines could be crossed unintentionally. Thus, though Musharraf does not appear to have ordered the attacks, the policy of maintaining proxies and devolving decision-making created the conditions in which they occurred. Such a situation would repeat itself in later years.

The Parliament attack ruptured the peace process between India and Pakistan, and set the two countries on the path to war. They also cracked the wall that Musharraf had attempted to build between the Kashmir jihad and the global war on terrorism. Having been forced to contend with Pakistani jihadi groups for many years, India now sought to tie those outfits to America's 'War on Terror.' New Delhi moved to cast the Kashmir issue as solely one of combating terrorism, and argued it had just as much a right to pursue militants from Pakistan as the US did to pursue al-Qaeda. Further, it used the American response of strikes against al-Qaeda as well as its hosts to buttress its case against Pakistan. In a demarche to Pakistan's High